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Presidential Telephone Calls - Memorandum of Conversations 1/23/89 - 5/10/89

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THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

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MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: The President's Telephone Call to West German
Chancellor Helmut Kohl

PARTICIPANTS: U.S.
The President

F.R.G.
Chancellor Kohl

DATE, TIME
AND PLACE: April 12, 1989, 7:55 a.m. - 8:05 a.m.
The White House

After an exchange of greetings, Chancellor Kohl noted that he had lots of work and lots of trouble, too. People have never been as well off as now, he observed, but they are more and more dissatisfied.

The President said he was calling about SNF (short-range nuclear forces), a thorny issue between our two sides and one that the rest of the Alliance is concerned about. The President recalled Kohl's telling him that our two sides would have early consultations and expressed disappointment that the Chancellor's national security advisor, Horst Teltschik, was not coming for this week's projected meeting in Washington.

The President emphasized that he very much wanted to have such consultations. If Teltschik -- or the Chancellor -- could come, it would be very, very helpful. The President said he recognized that the Chancellor's schedule might not permit him to come but hoped, at a minimum, that the Chancellor could send his national security advisor so that we can resolve this issue just as soon as possible.

Chancellor Kohl said he sees the situation exactly the same way but that this week and next he will be preoccupied with changing his government. The Chancellor said he was now in the midst of coalition negotiations to decide on new ministers; this was why Mr. Teltschik's visit was postponed. Two weeks ago, when he met in Austria with Ambassador Burt, the Chancellor felt there would

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be time for consultations, but the situation in Germany had changed so much that decisions on the coalition were needed now. The Chancellor said that he would call the President next week, just as soon as he had concluded the business at hand, and that he continued to believe that we can and must come to agreement before the Brussels summit.

The President replied that he hoped the Chancellor would call just as soon as possible, adding that we do not want to weaken the Alliance nor put the Chancellor, our friend and ally, on the line. The President said he found it puzzling that Foreign Minister Genscher had said there was an emerging consensus within the Bonn government in support of SNF arms negotiations. The President urged once again that the Chancellor come personally to Washington or send someone -- or receive the President's emissary in Bonn -- as soon as possible. Otherwise, the President concluded, the NATO summit will be beclouded by needless speculation.

Before a final exchange of greetings, Chancellor Kohl reiterated that he would be calling next week.

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